

this meant the use of analogue computers in Project Mercury (exploring the possibility of human flight to space) and digital computers for later programs like Apollo (lunar missions) as simulators, which were the primary means of training astronauts. Apart from training, computers were used for guidance, for communications with crews, and also for controlling all aspects of space craft behaviour—right from fine-tuning orbit speeds to recycling water and oxygen. Spin-offs from the space programme include communication technologies, semiconductor fabrication, virtual reality, keyboard designs, optical discs, and more.

1959

COBOL And Automation

Early 1959: Automated cheque-reading

The ERMA (Electronic Recording Machine, Accounting) system was installed at the Bank of America to automate the reading of cheques. Cheques were numbered using magnetic ink, which were read by a magnetic reader. The computer, which used both vacuum tubes and diodes and had more than a million feet in wiring, could read 10 cheques per second. The use of the ERMAs made Bank of America the market leader in its sector.

April: The MIT Artificial Intelligence Laboratory

The Artificial Intelligence Laboratory was set up at MIT by AI pioneers John McCarthy and Marvin Minsky. (The latter is known for his contributions to computational linguistics, optics, and robotics). It was a leading centre for research in AI, robotics, language, problems of vision, and mechanical manipulation. Richard Stallman, the free software activist, was one of the programmers who worked there.

May: COBOL

COBOL (COMmon Business Oriented Language), one of the oldest languages still in use, was created by a committee of industry



Marvin Minsky,
one of the
pioneers of AI